With 10 much-lauded books and a Padma Shri to his name, author Irwin Allan Sealy could take himself quite seriously. But nonchalance is his calling card. Ensconced in his retreat in Dehradun, the rather reclusive writer manages to mix the profound and the mundane. As he puts it, "*Jhaaru-pochha* is excellent for thinking: sociology unravels there." According to Sealy, if a writer can't be alone, he's better off working for a newspaper.

We discuss his latest book, *Flying Yoginis*, centred around the feisty female adepts of yoga, shape-shifting symbols of feminine power that aren't quite given their due in modern discourse. Carved in stone a thousand years ago in many places across India, often 64 in a vibrant congregation together, and now often found sitting alone in western museums. In today's times, where any interpretation of Hindu culture that is seemingly irreverent can draw flak, how freely could Sealy express his ideas? "There's no irreverence in my treatment of the yoginis; on the contrary, a great deal of respect, even affection. Here are supremely independent women—no males in the picture—capable, powerful creatures. They're also beautiful and lawless, and so immensely attractive. Above all, they're human, not divine. They are figures that compel your allegiance exactly as they did for ordinary petitioners, village women a thousand years ago, looking for redress to some injustice," he says.

While his fabulous first book *The Trotter-nama* (1990) was set in a fictitious place closely resembling Lucknow, the Booker-nominated *Everest Hotel* in 'Drummondganj' styled on Dehradun, and *Brainfever Bird* across Delhi and St Petersburg, *Flying Yoginis* seems to fly free of geographical moorings. Did he mean it to be a stream-of-consciousness-style book? "Certainly, it's a travelogue, a journey to the American deep south with yogini stops along the way. The piece does flow between reportage and reflection. The book came about thanks to an invitation to a literary conference in Madison, Wisconsin. Madison happened, I noticed, to be next door to a museum in Minneapolis that housed one of the dispersed yoginis from a vanished temple I'd been reading about. And then one thing led to another. That's also the way of fiction, which is almost always rooted in fact and best anchored to a specific place. The difference with travel is you can't make things up, and the telling is bound by your route."

How does he engage with a new destination that he visits? Does he see it through the eyes of a writer? "First of all, through the eyes of a foreigner, an outsider, only then as a writer taking notes," he replies. How did he come to be a writer? Perhaps fate played a role in that. Around 1960, when he was a boy in Bareilly, he came across a story by Ruskin Bond called 'The Boxwala'. "It was in *The Times of India* Sunday supplement, which I always looked out for, partly for the colour comic strips—that was TV for us. Now, I knew what a boxwala was: a peddler on a bike who brought around a glass-top case of buttons and bows, elastic and lace and embroidery silks for ladies like my mother, who loved needlework. Haberdashery at your door. But what was this boxwala doing among all the cool



FLYING YOGINIS
By Irwin Allan Sealy
SEAGULL BOOKS
₹699; 72 pages

FLYING YOGINIS IS CENTRED AROUND THE FEISTY FEMALE ADEPTS OF YOGA, SHAPE-SHIFTING SYMBOLS OF FEMININE POWER THAT AREN'T QUITE GIVEN THEIR DUE IN MODERN DISCOURSE